1-900-Desperate

By Christopher Durang

Scene: Gretchen, a woman in her mid-30s, is on the phone.

GRETCHEN: **(Pg 165-170)** No, mother, I don't have a date tonight. I know it's Saturday night. Yes, I know my sister Rebecca is married and has children. *(Listens.)* Well, I'm sorry my life makes you unhappy, mother. I'm very happy here alone in my apartment on Saturday. *(Listens some more; holds her head.)* Mother, please don't say that about me, you make me feel worthless and desperate. No, I don't want you to lie to me. No, I take that back - I ***do*** want you to lie to me. Tell me it's fine that I'm alone on Saturday night, and I'm fine. Say that, mother. ***Say it***. *(Listens; it's brief)* Thank you, mother, it's very sweet of you to feel that way. Now I have to go put my frozen dinner in the microwave, so let me get off the phone now. Goodnight. *(Grouchy.)* Yes, I love you too. *(Hangs up.)* Oh, thank God, I'm off the phone. *(Looks around; disoriented)* But what should I do now? Oh, I feel desperate.

VOICE: Feeling desperate? Then call 1-900-DESPERATE. That special someone may just be waiting for you.

INTRODUCTION

The 1980s . . . An era before cell phones. (looks shocked) I know, right? Cell phones were called telephones and were actually bolted to a wall with a cord connecting the "base" to the "receiver." Wow!

It was an era before social media, before texting and before on-line dating. Everyone, I'm told, relied on this so-called telephone to communicate. Welcome to the party line! Oh, that's a group phone call where people went to meet strangers in the mid-1980s. Think of it as a precursor to the internet chat room. But wait . . . there's more . . . you had to pay by the minute to participate. By the minute!! Let's face it. Meeting that special someone never gets any easier.

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VOICE: Call 1-900-DESPERATE. That special someone may just be waiting for you.

GRETCHEN: Oh, Lord, now I'm hearing voices. Oh that's right, the TV is on. I'm not crazy. I'm

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not crazy. I'm just desperate. *(Starts to dial.)* 1-900-Desperate. *(the sound of ringing, then a click and a recorded voice)*

RECORDED VOICE: Hello there, singles. You have reached 1-900-Desperate, where you can meet the man or woman of your dreams. The call costs $1.99 a half minute, $3.98 for a full minute. And there is a $25 minimum for 6 minutes and 28 seconds. If you don't want to be charged, hang up now. *(beat)* Too late. *(Gretchen is taken aback. She might have hung up, but it happened too fast)* You didn't hang up immediately, you might as well listen in on the line, we're going to charge you whatever you do. Enjoy yourself! *(another click)*

SALLY: *(Having heard the click of Gretchen coming on the line. She is overanxious to make a connection with someone)* Hello?

GRETCHEN: *(Tentative)* Hello? Is this 1-900-Desperate?

SALLY: It sure is. Are you a man with a high voice?

GRETCHEN: No, I'm a woman.

SALLY: Damn it. Are there any men on this line? Hello? Any men out there?

ZELDA: *(She seems to be on the line for purposes other than meeting people)* We've got to stop looking to men to give us meaning.

GRETCHEN: I think she's right. I have meaning even though I'm home alone on Saturday, thinking of renting a video and using the microwave.

ZELDA: You mean to kill yourself?

GRETCHEN: No. To cook.

LITTLE BOY: Hello?

SALLY: Are you a man?

LITTLE BOY: I'm five years old. My name is Billy.

SALLY: I don't care what your name is, shut up.

GRETCHEN: Please, don't be abusive to a child.

LITTLE BOY: *(Calls.)* I'm not doing anything, mommy. *(To the phone.)* Bye! *(hangs up)*

GRETCHEN: I guess I'd hang up too, but . . . I guess I've paid for it.

SALLY: Uh huh. Any men out there? Please God.

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ZELDA: Women were once warriors. We hunted like Diana, we carved the turkeys at dinner. We must return to those times.

SALLY: Will you shut up?

ZELDA: You need a woman's support group.

SALLY: I need a man. I don't need women yapping at me. *(Lights come up on Scuzzy, a kind of sexy 20-year-old with slicked-back hair and a leather jacket.)*

SCUZZY: Hey, ladies, how's it hangin'? You ladies feelin' desperate tonight?

SALLY: Oh my God, a man! Hello! Hello!

ZELDA: Not really. I'm reading the diaries of Anais Nin. She was very spiritual.

SCUZZY: Anyone else out there?

GRETCHEN: Yes. Although I can't stay long. I dialed by mistake.

SCUZZY: Ooooo. A happy mistake for me. What's your name, baby?

GRETCHEN: My name is . . . Gretchen.

SALLY: My name is Sally.

SCUZZY: What you look like, Gretchen?

GRETCHEN: Oh . . . I don't know.

SALLY: I look like a model. I have large breasts and a tiny waist and . . . do you like big or small hips?

SCUZZY: Who is this? I'm talkin' to Gretchen. Hey, Gretchen, talk to Scuzzy again.

GRETCHEN: What kind of name is Scuzzy?

SCUZZY: It's my nickname. You got a nickname?

GRETCHEN: Gretchen. Well, it's not a nickname . . . it's a name.

SALLY: Sometimes I *get excited* just walking down the street. That's the kind of passionate person I am.

SCUZZY: Butt out, butt head. I'm talkin' to Gretchen. Gretchen, you still there?

GRETCHEN: Excuse me. I think I'm going to get off now.

SCUZZY: You want me to call you? You know. On your number. We can have a "better talk" that way.

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GRETCHEN: Oh, I don't know, I don't feel I know you properly yet.

SCUZZY: What do you want to know?

GRETCHEN: Oh, gosh. What books do you read?

SCUZZY: Books. I read the TV Guide. *(Gretchen reacts non-verbally)*

LITTLE BOY: I have a little red wagon.

SCUZZY: Who the hell is that?

SALLY: Oh, I give up. I hate you all! *(Sally hangs up)*

SCUZZY: *(re-focuses)* What do you look like, Gretchen?

GRETCHEN: Well, let's see. I'm 5'9", I have brown eyes.

SCUZZY: What are your measurements? Heh, heh, heh.

GRETCHEN: Um . . . my measurements are 36-46-77. I look like a large teepee. And I invite men up to my lair and poison them at dinner and serve their bodies to the raccoons outside my house.

SCUZZY: Oooooh, this lady's intriguing!

ZELDA: Good for you, Gretchen. Feed him to the raccoons.

SCUZZY: We got a nut case on the line. Shut up, nut case! Hey, Gretchen, baby, gimme your number.

GRETCHEN: I'm sorry. I don't think we're right for one another. I'm sorry, Scuzzy. I'm sure you're very nice, for someone.

SCUZZY: Damn right I am. *(There is a pause.)*

LITTLE BOY: I have a little doggie, and a big doggie.

SCUZZY: Any hot chicks on the line?

ZELDA: *(With a glint, does a feminine, girlish voice.)* I'm here. Who's this?

SCUZZY: My name is Scuzzy.

ZELDA: Oh, I think I'm gonna like you, Scuzzy. Let me call you.

SCUZZY: Okay. My number's 666-0666.

ZELDA: Ooooh, that's a sexy number. I'll call you right up.

SCUZZY: Okay, baby. *(Scuzzy hangs up)*

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ZELDA: *(Regular voice.)* Good night, Gretchen. I'm gonna make him suffer. For you and for women everywhere. *(Zelda hangs up.)*

GRETCHEN: Well, calling this line has been a terrific success.

LITTLE BOY: I have a little red wagon.

GRETCHEN: Do you? That's nice.

LITTLE BOY: My mommy and daddy are asleep in front of the television. I'm five.

GRETCHEN: I'm thirty-five. I guess I could consider waiting for you. In fifteen years, you'll be twenty.

LITTLE BOY: I have a boo-boo on my knee and I can tie my shoelaces.

GRETCHEN: That's better than a lot of the men I know

LITTLE BOY: I have two doggies. And one's small, and one's big.

GRETCHEN: Really?

LITTLE BOY: And I have a teddy bear named Fred. And I can count to ten, and some higher numbers too. One, two ...

GRETCHEN: Really. How interesting.

LITTLE BOY: Three, four, five.

GRETCHEN: Uh huh ...

LITTLE BOY: Five. And six. And seven.

GRETCHEN: Uh huh ... *(Lights dim on the Little Boy counting and Gretchen going "uh huh" ...)*

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